in May, the TDP would rake up Jagan's faith, stoking Hindu emotions by claiming Christians were favoured over others under YSRCP rule. Naidu has also raised charges of forced conversions in the past, as has the state BJP. Visiting the 400-year-old Ramatheertham temple in 2021, where miscreants had desecrated a Ram idol, Naidu had alleged that it was the "127th attack on a Hindu temple" since the YSRCP took charge in 2019. Later, at a party meeting, he had declared: "Venkateswara Swamy is my dear god...if you win the election, you'll go to Jerusalem, but when I win, I'll go to Venkateswara Swamy. You can keep the Bible by your side, there's nothing wrong with that, but if there are attacks on Hindu temples, we won't sit idle."

Meanwhile, the current deputy CM, actor and JSP chief, Pawan 'Power Star' Kalyan, also waded energetically into the controversy. Kalyan declared he would do *prayaschitta deeksha* (penance) for the last government's sins at the Sri Dasavatara Venkateswara Swamy temple in Namburu, Guntur district. That concluded with him trekking barefoot up the Seven Hills in Tirumala alongside ordinary pilgrims on the night of October 1 to pray to Lord Venkateswara. Kalyan has also taken it upon himself to play custodian of the sanatana dharma, going so far as to tick off public figures who have spoken lightly about the laddoo episode.

ADDING FAT TO THE FIRE

The laddoo row may have sprung from political rivalries in Andhra Pradesh, but the controversy was sparked by a report of the National Dairy Development Board (NDDB) which suggests—with disclaimers—adulteration in the ghee and the possible presence of animal fat. The report was prepared by CALF (Centre of Analysis and Learning in Livestock and Food), a fully-owned subsidiary of the NDDB, which itself works under the central government's ministry of fisheries, animal husbandry and dairying. Officials at CALF refused to elaborate on the report, but sources claimed it did not specifically state that the adulterated ghee contained

THE MAKING OF THE TIRUPATI LADDOO

***For over 300 years, the Tirupati laddoo, also known as the Srivari laddoo, has been the primary offering at the Sri Venkateswara Swamy Temple. Amid concerns over the adulteration of ghee, a key ingredient of the laddoo, here's a look at the sacred* naivedyam**

₹500 CRORE
TTD's annual earning from laddoo sales

120 MILLION
Laddoos sold per annum

250,000-300,000
Laddoos rolled in a day

THE PROCESS...

Ingredients are procured through e-tenders and supplied to the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams's marketing office in Tirupati. From there, they are transported uphill to the Tirumala store where samples are checked before being sent for use



Bengal gram milled in Tirumala flour mills, away from the temple



Ghee supplied to the tank outside the temple. It is then pumped into the *potu* (sacred kitchen) through pipes



Besan paste prepared and boondi fried in ghee in the boondi *potu* outside the temple



Bundi in trays reach inside *potu* through conveyor belts



Sugar bags and other ingredients also transported



It is then mixed with the rest of the preparation and distributed to the devotees



The first laddoo of each batch is offered to the Lord

600 clean-shaven Vaishnavite Brahmins work in turn almost round the clock in an exclusive *potu* within the temple precincts



Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY